



2017

Acrobats on ice

The world-famous Cirque du Soleil performed its first circus show on ice, *Crystal*. Acrobats and ice skaters wowed the audience with their fearless stunts.

Born this day

1925 Dick Van Dyke, US actor and dancer. His 70-year career included film hits such as *Mary Poppins* and *Chitty Chitty Bang Bang*.

1967 Jamie Foxx, Black American actor and musician. His films include *The Amazing Spider-Man 2* and *Ray*. With four music albums to his name, he's also a Grammy winner.

December

13

2000

Plant DNA

Scientists decoded the first plant genome (set of genetic instructions), for a species known as *Arabidopsis thaliana*. This achievement made it possible to study which genes affect how a plant fights disease or survives with little water.

Also on this day

1545 At the Council of Trent, a group of Catholic bishops first met in Italy to discuss ways to reform the Catholic Church. This was in response to the rise of Protestantism, an alternative way to practise Christianity.

1939 World War II's first naval battle, the Battle of the River Plate, saw Germany fight the UK and New Zealand in the South Atlantic. It was a decisive victory for the Allies.

Snow in Egypt

2013

Egypt's capital city Cairo saw snow for the first time in 112 years as Storm Alexa battered countries in the Middle East with heavy snowfall and freezing temperatures.

